

No one likes bills. Especially when there's a lot to be shelled out, and when you have to stand in a queue to pay them. To our relief, a number of bill payment options have sprung up in recent years: one can now pay by cheque, Internet banking, telebanking, bill collection, cash cards, or even using a mobile phone.

Exploring this untapped potential are a number of companies coming up with innovative payment solutions. Payments by mobile is one of these, part of the evolution from e-commerce to m-commerce—mobile commerce.

The use of credit cards in India is nowhere as much as it is in Western countries. But even though the Internet penetration is high in urban India, people don't seem to be willing to make purchases online. This is fuelled in part by credit card fraud and the press coverage it gets; many people would never reveal their card number online. Some are even wary of handing over a card to a restaurant waiter, for example!

Illustration Chaitanya Surpur
Photograph Sandeep Patil

The Evolution Of PayMate

Every month, over four million users are added to the number of mobile phone subscribers in India. According to the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI), more than 65 million mobile phone subscribers were added in the year 2006, and there is a total of nearly 190 million mobile users in the country. A mobile is part of almost every second home, and is now being looked at for purposes beyond communication and entertainment.

Ajay Adiseshann and Probir Roy, founders of Corusant Tec, a mobile content developer and



Ditch That Wallet!

You can now pay bills using a mobile phone in India—the wave of m-commerce is upon us!

Samir Makwana

No comprehensive statistics are available for individual credit card fraud cases, but it is more than clear that consumers want a more secure payment option.

With the boom in the telecom industry and with big players in the market, mobile commerce has passed the nascent stage. Payment via mobile phone, which has existed for a while in developed countries, is now possible here as well. Not too many merchants might be accepting mobile payments as of now, but the idea is catching on.

services provider, founded PayMate India Ltd in July 2006. PayMate is a mobile commerce solution provider. PayMate's payment solution works on the "single SMS" model, wherein a registered user can make payments to a PayMate accredited merchant via a single SMS.

"Today, the mobile phone is part of everybody's life as a device for communication and entertainment. People use VAS (Value Added Services) from the content providers and mobile operators.

"We foresaw the potential of mobile phones as a commercial tool for transactions and